Topic 6 — Medieval Music & Culture

Covers syllabus (click to expand)

Medieval Music | Later Mughal (मुग़ल) Music | Mughal Court Patronage | Amir Khusrau (अमीर खुसरो) | Tansen (तानसेन) | Dhrupad (ध्रुपद) | Khayal (ख्याल) | Qawwali (क़व्वाली)

Sources baked in: NCERT *An Introduction to Indian Art*, Sangeet Ratnakar tradition, UPPCS Prelims PYQs 2018–2025 **Weight:** ★★★ — Tansen patronage, music treatise match, Tappa–Muhammad Shah, Chishti sama, Khusrau–Nizamuddin **Last verified:** August 2026 **Current Affairs:** N/A (purely historical)

6.1 Medieval Music — Overview

- Medieval Indian music fused **Sanskritic raga–tala (ताल) theory** with **Persianate court culture** and **Sufi devotion**.
- Theory roots remain older: **Natyashastra** (Bharata), **Brihaddeshi** (Matanga, who first used the word "raga" clearly), and **Sangeet Ratnakar** (Sharngadeva, 13th century, Devagiri (देवगिरी)).
- In the **Sultanate phase**, Amir Khusrau's Hindavi experiments and Chishti **sama** (musical assemblies) made music a bridge between religion and court.
- In the **Akbar phase**, imperial **dhrupad** patronage peaked with **Tansen** as a Navratna, and the Ain-i-Akbari (आइन-ए-अकबरी) records court musicians.
- In the **Later Mughal phase**, under **Muhammad Shah Rangeela**, **khayal** and **tappa** flowered, and imperial music became more intimate and lighter than Akbar's austere dhrupad.
- After the 12th–13th century, two classical branches emerged: **Hindustani** (north, with improvisation and gharana) and **Carnatic** (south, with kriti (कृति) and melakarta (मेलकर्ता)); this topic focuses on the **north/Mughal–Sultanate** stream.
- Later light classical centres in UP include **Lucknow–Banaras thumri** and **Kajri** (Mirzapur–Banaras belt), growing from medieval Awadh culture.

Logic: Tappa was **not** refined at Akbar's court. Tansen and Amir Khusrau were **not** contemporaries. The primary drum of dhrupad is **pakhawaj**, not tabla.

6.2 Mughal Court Patronage

- Mughal emperors used music as **imperial display** and cultural soft power, especially from **Akbar** onward.
- **Akbar** gave the strongest music patronage; **Tansen** was among the **Navratnas**, the court had Hindu and Muslim musicians, and the Ain-i-Akbari lists performers and instruments.

- **Jahangir** (जहाँगीर) continued court music, and his personal taste appears in **Tuzuk-i-Jahangiri** (तुज़ुक-ए-जहाँगीरी) (art and music notes).
- **Shah Jahan** (शाहजहाँ) maintained formal court culture where music remained important, though architecture dominates cultural memory.
- Tradition holds that **Aurangzeb** reduced music patronage, but music survived in **regional courts** and private mehfils.
- **Muhammad Shah Rangeela (1719–1748)** was the key later-Mughal music emperor, when **khayal** bloomed through **Sadarang and Adarang** and **tappa** was refined.
- Early Mughals favoured **dhrupad**, while later Mughals favoured **khayal and light forms**.
- Regional patrons also mattered: **Man Singh Tomar** (Gwalior) for early dhrupad, and **Raja Ramchandra of Bhata** for pre-Akbar Tansen.

6.3 Later Mughal Music

- After Aurangzeb, Delhi court culture shifted from heavy imperial ceremony to **mehfil-style** music.
- **Muhammad Shah Rangeela** is the central later-Mughal music figure for UPPCS.
- **Niyamat Khan Sadarang** and **Adarang** developed **khayal** into the dominant classical form.
- **Tappa** was refined at **Muhammad Shah Rangeela's** court (~1719–1748), not at Akbar's.

> [!TIP] **Exam Anchor — Tappa & 18th-Century Music (UPPCS Master Spine):** - **Tappa Style:** Originating from the rhythmic folk tunes of Punjabi camel drivers, *Tappa* was refined into a sophisticated semi-classical art form at the 18th-century imperial court of **Muhammad Shah 'Rangila'**. - **Khayal Masters:** Court composers **Sadarang (Niyamat Khan)** and **Adarang (Firoz Khan)** developed and popularized *Khayal gayaki* during this era.

- **Shori Miyan (Ghulam Nabi)** is the main tappa composer fact.
- Later decline of Delhi pushed musicians to **regional centres** such as Lucknow, Banaras, Patiala, and Gwalior, giving birth to modern **gharana** geography.
- Light forms linked to this aftermath include **thumri**, **dadra** (दादरा), and **ghazal** (ग़ज़ल); they matter for UP cultural geography, but the syllabus core remains khayal, tappa, and court music.

6.4 Amir Khusrau (Music Side)

Dates: 1253–1325 | **Guru (गुरु):** Nizamuddin Auliya | **Courts:** Balban, Alauddin Khalji (अलाउद्दीन खिलजी), Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq

- Amir Khusrau's music identity rests on pioneering **qawwali** and **tarana** and on Hindavi–Persian (फ़ारसी) cultural synthesis.
- **Qawwali** is Sufi congregational singing at khanqah (ख़ानक़ाह) or dargah and is linked to Chishti devotion.
- **Tarana** is a fast vocal form using syllables such as *tom, ta, der*, and tradition credits Khusrau with it.

- Folklore also credits Khusrau with inventing **sitar** and **tabla**; papers accept his "pioneer" status, though strict history (इतिहास) is more complex.
- **Ashiqa** is Khusrau's romantic masnavi; **Rag Vibodh** (*Raga Vibodha*, 1609) is **Somanath's** Sanskrit music treatise — never swap them.
- **Amir Khusrau's** guru was **Nizamuddin Auliya**.
- Khusrau did **not** serve Akbar's court; he died about **200 years** before Tansen's Mughal career.

> **Logic:** Khusrau was a Sultanate Sufi-music pioneer, while Tansen was Akbar's dhrupad master. Do not merge their eras.
>
> [!TIP] **Exam Anchor — Amir Khusrau's Spiritual & Musical Legacy (UPPCS Core):** - **Spiritual Master:** Amir Khusrau was the devoted chief disciple (*murid*) of **Hazrat Nizamuddin Auliya** (*Sultan-ul-Mashaikh*); died in October 1325 CE, six months after his Pir's passing. - **Musical Contributions:** Credited with creating the *Qawwali* form, developing *Tarana*, and innovating ragas like *Yaman* and *Sazgiri*.

6.5 Tansen

Identity: Greatest Hindustani dhrupad master of Akbar's court | **Navratna**

- Tansen was born **Ramtanu Pandey** near **Gwalior/Behat** and trained in the dhrupad tradition linked to Gwalior.
- **Before Akbar**, Tansen was patronised by **Raja Ramchandra Singh of Bhata (Rewa)**.
- Akbar invited him to court and gave him the title **Miyan Tansen**.
- Tansen's form was **dhrupad**, with **pakhawaj** as the accompaniment tradition.
- Ragas traditionally attributed to him include **Miyan Ki Todi**, **Miyan Ki Malhar**, and **Darbari Kanada**.
- The legend of **Deepak / Megh Malhar** (lighting lamps and bringing rain) is folklore, not hard history, but still appears in popular questions.
- Tansen died during Akbar's reign, and his tomb tradition is at **Gwalior**.
- The Senia tradition later linked his disciples to several north Indian schools.

> **Logic:** Pre-Akbar patron of Tansen was **Bhata/Rewa**, not Mewar (मेवाड़), Malwa, or Gujarat.
>
> [!TIP] **Exam Anchor — Mian Tansen's Lineage & Patrons (UPPCS & IAS Format):** - **Birth & Training:** Born **Ramtanu Pandey**; trained under master **Swami Haridas** of Vrindavan. - **Pre-Akbar Patron:** Served as the royal court musician of **Raja Ramchandra Singh** of Rewa (Bhata region), who patronized him before Akbar summoned him in 1562 CE. - **Titles:** Conferred the title *Tansen* by Raja Vikramjit of Gwalior, *Mian* and *Kanthabharanvanivilas* by Akbar. - **Muslim Name & Tomb:** After conversion, named **Ata Ali Khan**; buried at **Gwalior** near the tomb of Sufi saint Hazrat Muhammad Ghaus.

6.6 Dhrupad

- **Dhrupad** is the **oldest surviving Hindustani art form**, with austere temple and court gravity and a slow alap leading into composition.
- Its primary drum is the **pakhawaj**, not the tabla.
- Its early court home was **Raja Man Singh (राजा मान सिंह) Tomar** of **Gwalior** in the late fifteenth and early sixteenth centuries.
- Imperial patronage peaked under **Akbar** with **Tansen** as the Navratna dhrupad master.
- Performance structure begins with a long **alap**, then a composed bandish, and stays less ornamental than later khayal.
- Major banis (styles) include Dagar, Nauhar, Khandar, and Gauhar; the Dagar bani is the best-known revival line.
- For papers, remember that **dhrupad goes with pakhawaj and Akbar/Tansen**, while **khayal goes with tabla and the Muhammad Shah era bloom**.

6.7 Khayal

- **Khayal** ("imagination") became the **dominant Hindustani concert form** after the later Mughal mehfil age.
- It uses the **tabla** as its drum, not the pakhawaj of dhrupad.
- It has **bada khayal** (slow and expansive) and **chhota khayal** (faster).
- Its bloom is linked to **Sadarang (Niyamat Khan)** and **Adarang** at **Muhammad Shah Rangeela's** court.
- Khayal is more flexible and ornamental than dhrupad, with improvisation and bol-taans at the centre.
- It was later institutionalised through **gharanas**; Gwalior is the oldest khayal gharana, and **Agra** (आगरा) has a strong Uttar Pradesh (उत्तर प्रदेश) link.
- Do **not** credit khayal's main flowering to Akbar; Akbar's signature form is dhrupad.

6.8 Qawwali

- **Qawwali** is Sufi devotional chorus music with call-and-response, handclaps, and later harmonium and tabla support.
- Tradition links its origin and popularisation to **Amir Khusrau** in the **Nizamuddin** circle.
- It is connected to Chishti **sama**, the musical assembly treated as a path to divine ecstasy.
- Early Chishti fondness for **sama** is true, but it does **not** fully explain why Sanskrit music works were translated into Persian — both statements can be true without R explaining A.
- Qawwali centres include Delhi dargahs around Nizamuddin and the Ajmer (अजमेर) Sharif lineage of Chishti devotion.
- Qawwali is distinct from classical **dhrupad and khayal**; it is a religious mehfil form, not a Navratna court concert form.

[!TIP] **Exam Anchor — Sanskrit Music Treatises in Persian Translation (UPPCS Format):** - **Assertion (A):** Many Sanskrit treatises on Indian classical music were translated into Persian during the medieval period. (True — patronized by Firuz Tughluq, Sikandar Lodi, and Mughal emperors). - **Reason (R):** The early Chishti Sufis were fond of musical assemblies called *Sama*. (True, but (R) is NOT the correct causal explanation of (A)).

6.9 Music Treatises (High-ROI Match Set)

Text	Author	One-line fact
Ragamala (रागमाला)	**Pundrik Vitthal**	Raga–ragini families
Rasa Kaumudi	**Sri Kantha**	Music + dance + rasa
Raga Vibodh / Ragavibodha	**Somanath** (~1610)	Janya (जन्य)–janaka; veena description
Chaturdandi Prakashika (चतुर्दंडी प्रकाशिका)	**Venkatraman / Venkatamakhin**	Melakarta theory (Carnatic)

- Music-treatise pairs: **Ragamala–Pundrik**, **Rasa Kaumudi–Sri Kantha**, **Raga Vibodh–Somanath**, **Chaturdandi–Venkatraman**.
- The same music-treatise pairs recur: Pundrik–Ragamala, Sri Kantha–Rasa Kaumudi, Somanath–Raga Vibodh, Venkatraman–Chaturdandi.
- Related older texts for context include **Sangeet Ratnakar** by Sharngadeva and **Natyashastra** by Bharata.

Logic: Ashiqa is Khusrau's masnavi; **Raga Vibodh** is by **Somanath**. Do not swap them in match lists.

[!TIP] **Exam Anchor — Classical Music Treatises Alignment (UPPCS Master Spine):** - **Ragamala:** Pundarika Vitthala - **Rasa Kaumudi:** Srikantha - **Raga Vibodha:** Somanatha (1609 CE) - **Chaturdandi Prakashika:** Venkatamakhin (father of Carnatic 72-Melakarta system) - **Sangita Ratnakara:** Sarangadeva (13th c. Yadava court of Devagiri) - **Man Kautuhal:** Raja Man Singh Tomar of Gwalior

2. (UPPCS Prelims 2022, Q108) Match List-I (Work) with List-II (Author): - Re-tested the identical four treatises: **Ragamala** (Pundarika Vitthala), **Rasa Kaumudi** (Srikantha), **Raga Vibodha** (Somanatha), and **Chaturdandi Prakashika** (Venkatamakhin). Verified official answer: **A (3-4-1-2)**.

6.10 Master Fact-Locks — Mughal Painting Ateliers & Classical Music

Category / Entity	Specific Details & Exam Anchors	Core Significance
Foundations of Mughal Painting	• **Humayun** recruited two master Persian artists during his exile: **Khwaja Abdus Samad** and **Mir Sayyid Ali**. • Humayun and young Akbar took drawing lessons directly from them, founding the Mughal atelier.	Genesis of Mughal miniature art
Hamzanama (Dastan-i-Amir Hamza)	• First major monumental painting enterprise undertaken under **Akbar**. • Executed over **15 years** by ~50 painters under the successive supervision of Mir Sayyid Ali and Abdus Samad; comprised ~**1,400 large cloth paintings**.	Earliest mature Akbari manuscript
Akbar's Tasvir Khana	• Established imperial painting workshops (**Tasvir Khana** / *Karkhanas*). • Court painters: **Daswant** (son of a potter, chief illustrator of *Razmnama*, committed suicide), **Basawan**, Keshav Lal, Mukund, Miskin, Farrukh, Jagan, Mahesh. • **European Influence:** Portuguese Jesuits introduced Western techniques: individual realistic portraiture, three-dimensional shading, and perspective (distant objects rendered smaller).	Akbari realism and synthesis
Jahangir — Golden Age of Painting	• Shifted the art form from book illustrations to **independent portraits**, nature studies, and imperial albums (*muraqqa*). • **Abul Hasan:** Conferred title ***Nadir-ul-Zaman*** (*"Wonder of the Age"*); painted Jahangir's accession on the frontispiece of *Tuzuk-i-Jahangiri*. • **Ustad Mansur:** Conferred title ***Nadir-ul-Asra*** (*"Wonder of the Epoch"*); celebrated ornithological and botanical master (Siberian crane, Bengal florican, dodo, floral studies). • **Bishan Das:** Master portrait painter sent with the Mughal embassy to Safavid Persia to paint Shah Abbas I. • Other Jahangiri masters: Manohar, Farrukh Beg, Aqa Riza, Govardhan, Muhammad Nadir.	Pinnacle of miniature painting
Regional Painting Schools	• **Pahari, Rajasthani, and Kangra Schools:** Regional offshoots directly nurtured by Mughal miniature techniques and departing court artists. • **Kalighat Painting:** Indigenous Bengal folk school based around the Kali temple of Calcutta, **NOT affected** by Mughal court miniature traditions. • **Kishangarh School (Rajasthan):** Famous for the iconic, stylized portrait of ***Bani Thani*** (the *"Indian Mona Lisa"*), painted by **Nihal Chand** under the patron-poet king **Raja Sawant Singh (Nagri Das)**.	Regional miniature schools

Category / Entity	Specific Details & Exam Anchors	Core Significance
Swami Haridas & 5 Worship Ashrams	Renowned spiritual poet and Dhrupad master of the *Haridasi (Sakhi Bhava)* sampradaya in Vrindavan; teacher of Tansen, Baiju Bawra, and Gopal Nayak. His disciples established **5 sacred worship centers** (ashrams): 1. Sri Banke Bihariji 2. Nidhivan 3. Temple of Gorelal 4. Sri Rasik Bihari 5. Thatti Khana	Sacred music centers of Vrindavan
Aurangzeb's Instrumental Mastery	Banned court vocal and instrumental music as anti-Islamic, yet was himself an accomplished master of the classical Indian instrument **Veena**. The largest number of Persian treatises on Indian classical music were written during his reign.	Irony of Aurangzeb's music policy
Morning Raga — Todi	Hindustani classical raga sung in the early morning; traditionally performed by royal minstrels, Bhats, and Charans to awaken the sovereign.	Classical raga time-theory
Raja Man Singh Tomar of Gwalior	Great 15th-century patron of Dhrupad music; authored the celebrated treatise *Man Kautuhal*; invented the raga ***Mal Gurjari***.	Gwalior Dhrupad tradition